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PREVIEW

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**The silent poetry and the invisible painting: A concept of
relationship between painting and poetry as seen in analysis
of selected writing and works by Leonardo da Vinci and Su
Tung-po**

Bao, Yuheng, Ph.D.

Ohio University, 1991

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PREVIEW

THE SILENT POETRY AND THE INVISIBLE PAINTING
A CONCEPT OF RELATIONSHIP BETWEEN PAINTING AND POETRY
AS SEEN IN ANALYSIS OF SELECTED WRITING AND WORKS
BY LEONARDO DA VINCI AND SU TUNG-PO

A DISSERTATION PRESENTED TO
THE FACULTY OF THE SCHOOL OF COMPARATIVE ARTS
THE COLLEGE OF FINE ARTS
OHIO UNIVERSITY

In Partial Fulfillment
of the Requirement for the Degree
Doctor of Philosophy

BY

Yuheng Bao

June, 1991

This dissertation has been approved
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Yuheng Bao

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THE ABSTRACT

Bao, Yuheng. Ph.D. June, 1991, Comparative Arts

The Silent Poetry and the Invisible Painting: A Concept of Relationship between Painting and Poetry as seen in Analysis of Selected Writing and Works by Leonardo da Vinci and Su Tung-Po
(310 pp.)

Director of Dissertation: Dr. Jessica Haigney

Based on the idea of Comparative Arts: West-East study, following the method of synthesis, this dissertation uses analysis of selected writings and works of Leonardo da Vinci of the Italian Renaissance and Su Shih of the Sung Dynasty of China to discuss the relationship between painting and poetry. The central question is: "Is there a similarity of views between Chinese and Western traditions on the concept of the relationship between painting and poetry?" The further purpose of the dissertation is to determine whether or not this similarity is useful for us as a "bridge" for the understanding of Western and Eastern arts.

This study approaches the analogy from an interdisciplinary standpoint as well as from the view of a comparative study of Western and Eastern arts. It strives to illuminate Western and Eastern painting and poetry, specifically in comparing Italian Renaissance painting and poetry in the sixteenth century with Chinese Sung Dynasty painting and poetry in the eleventh to twelfth centuries. This study also applies the method of art historical analysis as well as aesthetic analysis to the pictorial imagery of Renaissance and Sung poetries, and to the poetic expression of their painting.

The dissertation is divided into three parts. First, the writer proposes to isolate the concept of the relationship between painting and poetry in Chinese art as seen in Su's writing and works, and to investigate the cultural and philosophical elements bearing upon this relationship. Second, the writer isolates a similar concept of the relationship between painting and poetry in Renaissance art as seen in Leonardo's writing and works, and pursues an identical investigation of relevant cultural and philosophical elements. Finally, by bringing the two investigations together for comparison, the writer points out the parallel elements, and in this way discusses the relationship between Western and Eastern arts.

From the discussion, the writer finds that both Su Shih and Leonardo da Vinci stated the common truth of art. Poetry and painting are aesthetically unified in the sense that both transcend physical reality to arouse a feeling of something beyond or outside. This common truth of art can transcend the political and cultural boundaries and belong to the universal. By using the concept of Comparative Arts: West-East study, we can easily find the common points between Western and Eastern arts, in this way this kind of comparative arts study can serve as a bridge for the understanding of the relationship between Western and Eastern arts.

Approved


Signature of Director

INTRODUCTION

The question of the relationship between painting and poetry is a very important topic in the study of art--both in the study of art history and the study of art theory. For over the centuries, this topic has caused controversy: philosophers of aesthetics and of history, historians of cultures and of art, critics of art and of literature, and the artists themselves--painters and poets--have had great arguments on this topic, each on his own assumptions, and each to his own purpose.

Among artists, for example, some Chinese painters of Southern School in the Ming Dynasty (during 14th till 17th centuries) have related painting to poetry in order to make it acceptably humanistic, only for some sociological or philosophical reasons.¹ Other artists, such as Leonardo da Vinci, have compared the two arts in order to define a close relationship between these "sister arts" or to demonstrate the superiority of graphic expression to verbal expression. Some aestheticians, such as Lessing and Croce, have been concerned

1. See Qian Zhong-shu, Chinese Poetry and Chinese Painting, in The Seven Essays on Arts, (Shangshi:1985). p.6-10. Also see Susan Bush, The Chinese Literati on Painting, Chapter V: The Northern and Southern Schools. pp. 158-72.

with this analogy in order either to define the aesthetic value peculiar to each medium, or to discover a beauty which transcends both arts. Some historians have sought the "Zeitgeist"--Time-Spirit--that they believe lies behind the historical context to compare one kind of painting with a parallel kind of poem, for example, to compare landscape painting with descriptive poetry.²

This discussion differs from such studies in aim and method. It approaches the analogy from an interdisciplinary standpoint as well as from the view of a comparative study of Western and Eastern arts. It strives to illuminate Western and Eastern painting and poetry, specifically in comparing Italian Renaissance painting and poetry in the sixteenth century with Chinese Sung Dynasty painting and poetry in the eleventh to twelfth centuries. This study will apply the method of art historical analysis to the pictorial imagery of Renaissance and Sung poetries, as well as to the poetic expression of their painting. But the aim of this study is somewhat broader than it might first appear. It will use analysis of selected writings and the works of Su Tung-po of China and Leonardo da Vinci of Italy to discern a relationship between Chinese and Western traditions.

The study will investigate the question: "Is there a

2. See W. Lee Rensselaer, Ut Pictura Poesis: The Humanistic Theory of Painting (New York, 1967), and Jean H. Hagstrum, The Sister Arts (Chicago: University of Chicago, 1958).

similarity of views between the Chinese and Western traditions on the concept of the relationship between poetry and painting?"

Through the analysis of selected writings and art works of Su Tung-po and Leonardo da Vinci, the writer will discuss differences and similarities of views between the Chinese and Western concepts of the relationship between the two arts of painting and poetry.

From art historical scholarship, we know that in the West the comparison between poetry and painting appeared in the classical period, and was revived at the time of the Italian Renaissance.³ In China, painting was not equated with poetry until about the eleventh century in the Sung Dynasty when it became an important concept that had a great influence on Chinese literature and art.⁴

There are several apparent similarities in Chinese and Western tradition on the concept of the relationship between poetry and painting. They may be summarized as follows:

First, both in the West and in China, the comparison between poetry and painting, as well as the stress on the education of painters, helped to establish the status of painting as liberal art.⁵

3. See Jean H. Hagstrum, The Sister Arts (Chicago: Chicago University Press 1957) pp. 3-37.

4. See Li Ze-hou and Liu Gang-ji, eds., The History of the Aesthetics of China (Beijing, 1984). Preface. p. 3-5

5. see Qian Zhong-shu, Chinese Poetry and Chinese Painting pp. 4-7.

Second, since there were no ancient theoretical treatises on painting, poetic theory became the model for art criticism.⁶

Third, sometimes painters and poets dealt with similar mythological, historical, and poetic subject matter, so some scholars pointed out painting could be thought of as a form of literary illustration in a certain sense.⁷

Despite these obvious similarities, certain significant differences must be pointed out. In China, eminent Chinese artists were always scholars, or men of high social standing: hence, the element of literary skill was assumed very important in their art creation and criticism. In the West, distinctions between poetry and painting were repeatedly pointed out or discussed. In China, however, these distinctions were not noted. The equality of painting and poetry was emphasized repeatedly, possibly because in China these two arts, being produced with the same materials--using the same brush and ink, and having the same style of scrolls--were intimately related.

6. Ibid. pp.31. Also see Susan Bush, The Chinese Literature on Painting, (Harvard University Press, 1971) pp. 7-9.

7. See Zong Baihua, The Idea of Space In Chinese Poetry and Painting, (Beijing, 1984), Lin Yutang, The Chinese Theory of Art: Translation From the Masters of Chinese Art (London: William Heinemann, 1967). and Michael Sullivan, The Art of China rev. ed. (Berkeley: University of California, 1967). Many Chinese and American scholars, have already done very good studies on these points.

The most complex and fundamental difference, however, involves the attitude toward art and nature in these two different cultures. In the West, poetry and painting tended to be compared in periods of pictorial naturalism.⁸ In the Renaissance, painting was associated with the literal depiction of the visible world, and was seen as an art that could rival science in its exactness. Poets then and later envied the paintings' descriptive power.⁹ But Chinese painting always strived for the status of poetry, not of science. Despite changing evaluations of the function of painting, most Chinese art critics remained consistent in their low estimate of formal likenesses. For them, painting, like poetry, could fuse mood and scene, joining the subjective and objective worlds in the artist's vision.¹⁰ It is interesting to note that despite these differences, some Western artists and some Chinese artists had similar points of view on the relationship between poetry and painting.

Leonardo da Vinci, the great master of the Renaissance age, once stated, "Painting is a poetry that is seen and not

8. See Jean H. Hagstrum, The Sister Arts, p. 59.

9. For the influence of this kind of comparison in Western poetry and literary theory, see Jean H. Hagstrum, The Sister Arts, pp. 57-93.

10. See Zong Baihua, The Birth of Yijian Chinese Art in his Walking in the Fields of Aesthetics (Mei Xue San Bu Shanghai: People Press, 1982) pp.61.

heard (una poesia muta); / and poetry is a painting that is heard and not seen (una pittura cicca)."¹¹ In China, Su Shih, the great master of the Sung Dynasty, in his poem "For the Painting of a Horse by Han Gan" stated: "The writings of Shao Ling are paintings without forms; /The paintings of Han Gan are poems without sound."¹²

Painting was considered "the silent poetry" or "the poem without sound," while poetry was "the sound painting" or "the painting without form." Both Leonardo and Su had the same comments: Silent poetry is seen, not heard, while sound painting is heard, not seen. These comments demonstrate the similar concept of the relationship between poetry and painting.

In the article A Western View on Chinese Arts written by Jessica Haigney and Robert Wortman, the two scholars stated:

'Each of the media of expression in the arts of China has its own history and traditions just as they do in the West. As is also the case in the West, each of them has its own treatises and instruction manuals designed to inform and instruct young artists in earlier practice. Further, these documents often contain descriptions or critical commentary on the practice of art in their own time. Just as we are taught to do within our own Western tradition, we need

11. Leonardo da Vinci, Trattato Della Pittura, trans. G.Milanesi, ed. A. P. McMahan, (Princeton, 1956), pp.17.

12. Su Tung-po, The Complete Poems of Sung, (in Chinese Qian Sung Shi, Beijing, Classic Press, 1956) Vol.VI. pp.3453, trans. by Bao Yuheng. Here Shao Ling is the pen name of the poet Du Fu, and Han Gan is a painter of the Tang Dynasty.

to be alert to the qualifications of the writers of these treatises. It is one thing for a practitioner of an art to pass on what he has learned to the younger generation; it may be another matter if the writer himself is distanced from actual practice.¹³

Both Leonardo and Su are just these kinds of masters. On one hand their concepts on the relationship between poetry and painting continue the tradition in the history of each artist's culture; on the other hand, their concepts and ideas contain descriptions or critical commentary on the practice of art in their own time. Furthermore, both Leonardo and Su are artists themselves. Their own works of art can also be considered as reflections of their own ideas. The two masters' concepts on the relationship between poetry and painting also state a common truth that great ideas and thoughts do not drop from the sky. The great ideas come from certain kinds of social structures, social circumstances, and social practices.¹⁴

From the study or discussion of both Su's and Leonardo's concepts and ideas of the relationship between poetry and painting, we can start a comparative study of Eastern-Western

13. Jessica Haigney and Robert Wortman, A Western View on Chinese Art, Chinese translation was published in Contemporary Foreign Art by the Institute of Foreign Arts, the Academy of Arts of China, No. 13, 1990. pp. 96.

14. See Lin Yutang, The Gay Genius: The Life and Times of Su Tung-po (Connecticut: Greenwood Press, 1971) pp.274. And Jack Wassern, Leonardo da Vinci (New York: Harry N. Abrams, 1975) pp.11-57.

Arts. We are facing a problem of method. Here I think we can borrow some ideas from Comparative Literature. In 1979, Dr. Heh-hsiang Yuan, a scholar of Comparative Literature, defined "Comparative Literature East-West" as:

...a branch of literary study which compares literary works of both the East and the West beyond the confines of national boundaries, seeking mutual understanding through exchange and comparison of ideas, denying not the uniqueness of a national tradition but giving its manifestation a new dimension and making Comparative Literature a universal medium of communication.¹⁵

Yuan's definition has been accepted and praised by many scholars. For example, Dr. A. Owen Aldridge points out that Yuan's major contribution to Comparative Literature East-West "consists in successfully formulating a working definition, if not an absolute one."¹⁶

From Yuan's idea of Comparative Literature we can also make our own definition of Comparative Arts East-West Study. It might read like this: "A branch of art study which compares works of art as well as ideas of art of both the West and the East beyond the confines of national boundaries and medium, seeking mutual understanding through exchange and comparison of ideas, not denying the uniqueness of a national tradition or

15. Heh-hsiang Yuan, "East-West Comparative Literature: An Inquiry Into Possibilities" in Chinese-Western Comparative Literature: Theory and Strategy (Hong Kong: Chinese University Press, 1980) pp.3

16. Ibid. pp. vii.

medium but giving its manifestation a new dimension and making Comparative Art a universal medium of communication."

It is true that the differences of national or cultural heritages of the West and the East often make this kind of comparative study more difficult. As Dr. Anthony Thorlby points out, different artistic traditions more often than not elude our apprehension. But if we accept divergence without imposing any value judgement, without any discrimination, cultural variety and differences would then only constitute interesting subjects for exploration rather than prejudice for exploitation. A comparatist should realize that distinction is not division, that "in order to obtain adequate notions of any truth," he must "intellectually separate its distinguishable parts without breaking their interrelatedness."¹⁷

Anthony Thorlby describes the ideal comparatist in this way:

The comparatist needs only accept one self-evident principle of aesthetic awareness, which is valid in all arts; that to see one poem, or one picture, or one building is to have little feeling for its qualities. To see another example of the 'same' thing, which being another work of art is of course not the same but only 'comparable,' is to take the first step towards recognizing what is in each case good, original, difficult, intended. There need be no factual connection between the two examples, but the comparatist must know how to juxtapose them. If he goes far afield for his comparisons, this is

17. Anthony Thorlby, Comparative Literature in The Yearbook of Comparative and General Literature Vol.18 (1969), p. 79.

not in order to prove any thesis of universal philology or historical evolution or structural aesthetics, but primarily for the pleasure of the thing, to broaden the base of his experience, as an adventure.¹⁸

This broadening of experience, as many scholars have pointed out is, by nature, humanistic.

As Mr. Heh-hsiang Yuan's statement of comparative literature reveals:

It constitutes a field that is so 'vast and vague, so centrally located and tangentially defined' that can never be sure where its frontiers lie.... Such a subject calls for discussion that seeks common grounds for all traditions by pushing through the cultural and philosophical limits towards the speculative horizons of the various nations represented in the discipline. A comparatist must assume an equal belief in the equal validity of all traditions constituting the unity of knowledge.¹⁹

A comparatist must stand between two national traditions. He must be positive but not partial towards either one. He must not adhere to a single national tradition, for this "negative freedom" must liberate him from rigid conventions and allow him an opportunity for a "creative openness" to new possibilities. This is, as many scholars have named, an internationalist principle of comparative studies.²⁰

Such an internationalist principle about the study of arts

18. Ibid. pp.80-81.

19. Heh-hsiang Yuan, pp. 4-5.

20. Rene Etiemble, The Crisis in Comparative Literature (Michigan State University Press, 1966). pp. 9.

and literature provides a comparatist a richer storehouse of examples, "enriches the study of any single national literature and arts, and widens the intellectual contact among scholars and students of all nations"²¹

This internationalist principle of comparative studies is also the principle of my study. Following this principle my study will attempt to establish a bridge of understanding across the cultural gap between Western and Eastern arts. This is the final goal of my study.

21. Heh-hsiang Yuan, pp. 5-6. Also see Rene Etiemble's words in his book The Crisis of Comparative Literature:

"It seemed to me useful to recall, ...two formulae, which I see as the credo of all comparatists:

The previous local and national isolation in which each one was self-sufficient is being replaced by a universal interdependence of nations. What is true of material production is equally applicable to intellectual production. A nation's works become the common property of all nations. National narrowness of mind and xenophobia are becoming more and more impossible; from the roots of numerous national and even provincial literature henceforth will flower a universal literature. (Karl Marx) / If I know something useful to me but injurious to my family, I would reject it from my mind. If I knew something useful to my family but not to my country, I would try to expunge it. If I knew something useful to my country but prejudicial to Europe, or else useful to Europe but inimical to mankind, I would view it as a crime. (Montesquieu)"

These principles of Montesquieu and Karl Marx, Etiemble calls the internationalist principles for comparative studies.

Many scholars of comparative studies, such as Paul van Tieghem, Rene Wellek, A. Owen Aldridge, W. Wolfgang Holdheim, Michael Sullivan, Joseph Needham, Robert Wortman, William Yip, Qian Zhongshu, Zhu Guangqian, and Zong Baihua, to name only a few, have already successfully used some methods of synthesis in their studies. The most important point is that these kinds of methods of synthesis have established a new attitude of viewing and thinking: a positive, habitual, and creative way of thinking which can lead us to view Literature and Art from an interdisciplinatory and three-dimensional angle or point of view. Here I use the term "Literature" and "Art" only to repeat Dr. Rene Wellek's concept, for he made a statement which calls for deep thought: Once when discussing the study of comparative literature he said, "we are studying LITERATURE, not only studying French or English literature. This can be the banner of Comparative Literature."²² We need state firmly that we are studying ART.

We are studying ART, and we are studying it from an interdisciplinary and three-dimensional approach. It is an interdisciplinary approach, for it studies not only the relationship between different kinds of art, such as the

22. See Melvin Friedman's review of Comparative Literature Matter and Method ed. by A. Owen Aldridge. Comparative Literature Studies No. 7 (March 1970). pp.84-86.